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Albert Murray

For the last 25 years, Albert Murray has been one of America's most influential writers. From his first book The Omni Americans *(1970) to his current* The Seven League Boots*, Mr. Murray has provided a unique perspective on American culture. In* Stomping the Blues *(1976) he offered a compelling paradigm for the importance of jazz and blues in America and his ten year collaboration with Count Basie resulted in Basie's definitive biography* Good Morning Blues. *Mr. Murray has acted as a mentor to a number of this country's leading musicians and scholars and his efforts helped make Jazz at Lincoln Center a reality. Mr. Murray received an honorary doctorate from Hamilton College in May of 1997.*

He was interviewed in Clinton, New York on September 24, 1997 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. Tim Hicks participated briefly in the interview.

MR: We're filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and I'm very honored to have writer and scholar Albert Murray with us. Welcome back to Hamilton.

AM: Thank you.

MR: It was our pleasure to give you an honorary doctorate in May, and we're glad to have you back. You're actually here to talk about William Faulkner this afternoon.

AM: Right.

MR: And we've been keeping you pretty busy on campus today. You said a couple of things at lunch today that I just had to ask you a little more about. And one was your definition of yourself as an American and when you define yourself as an American, talking about the crossing from Africa of the slave ships and so forth. Can you give me an idea about how black Americans define themselves?

AM: I'd prefer not to talk about that. I think it's a lot of confusion about that that's based on political maneuvering and has very little to do with an actual historic basis for definition. The stuff I'm interested in, defining my role as an American and the ways that the idiom that I grew up in add up to a definition of American character. But I don't see any particular value in discussing what most people do because they get their images from sociology, from political strategy and stuff like this, more propaganda and stuff. It's not very relevant. I just find it boring and confusing and all of this is counterproductive. It works against what their objectives are. Because I don't see but one objective, and that's to enjoy all of your birthright as an American. And that means achieving a synthesis of the most valuable and useful aspects of the American proposition, American culture and whatnot. And all Americans have problems of one sort or another, but they have individual personalities and individual goals and so forth, and you simply have to deal

with what the problems are. And I feel it's literature, and so I'm interested in adequate images of the American experience and I assume the responsibility or part of the responsibility for the leadership of America in the world in terms of the human proposition that should be the basis of twentieth century living and I've spent quite a part of the twentieth century, eighty years of American life and all, and I've been a student of American culture and so forth, and I find that you know political formulations and things like that are not very, very useful, they're propaganda, except they're useful in a negative sense. They can get people mis-definitions of what they're about and they forget to deal with themselves as human beings and they deal with themselves as abstractions from not life as data but ideological approaches which have to do with vested interests in certain aspects of American life.

MR: When you were in your Air Force career, in your Air Force days, did you have aspirations to be a writer at that time also?

AM: Oh yeah, I had been a college teacher before I was in the Air Force. I was drafted into the service and I had to do my time, during World War II, but I had already finished college and I was involved with literature. This was just another experience to me. But I had no basic images about being efficient, as I'd been taught to be in school. And I went to school from primary grade through high school and Mobile College Training School on the outskirts of Mobile. And it was geared to making responsible American citizens. That's what it was about. And deal with whatever problems — it's just like you have the general problems then you have individual, personal problems. And ultimately you deal with the problems that are personal to you, and you want to see what you can do about it, how far your abilities can take you, and that type of thing. That's what I was always about.

MR: You often read the idea that people call jazz the only true American art form, and I'm wondering, are they separating blues from that do you feel? Blues is certainly an American art form. We were talking earlier about how it's a synthesis of what people experience in this country.

AM: See I just see jazz as a fully orchestrated blues statement. I mean if you say blues, generally people are talking about folk blues. And that's a very limited art form. But as extended, elaborated and refined by the most inventive musicians in the idiom which created the blues, you have jazz. The function of jazz of course is always to get rid of the blues, that is the blues as such, you know, having the blues. But blues music, most people are talking about a folk form and most people who deal with it don't know anything about it, they just have made up their minds and basically their conception comes from sociology and political history and things like that that have nothing to do with the existential problems that the blues is concerned with. I don't understand that, really,

because there's very little in the blues that has to do with political situations. You know it's really a ridiculous type thing, a position where college professors and writers and so forth impose study on something which has nothing to do with what the blues musician is doing. The musician lives on the level of existential preoccupation. He is concerned with the quality of life. He's not concerned with forms of government, economics, discrimination, things like that are not part of our subjects of the blues. And people keep acting as if they were. They are not. They're about — the lyric poetry of almost any culture has to do with love. But blues is about love, about the relationship of men and women, about betrayal. If you get money, it's only about a love story, it's about somebody who's going with this girl and then he lost his job or he couldn't give her an expensive presents and he had to be the type of person who loved her. It's not talking about discrimination and racism and things like that. I know very few blues musicians that are concerned with that. They're concerned with a good time, having a good time, they play the blues in honky tonks and places like that, not when people are out in a bad mood, but when they're looking for fun. And yet we get all this talk about it as if that's what it's about. All you have to do is to go to any church and listen to the preacher talk about the blues. And he calls it "good time music." He does not say this is the music that's commensurate with this. The church didn't even deal with that 40 years ago. I mean I've never been to a church where the preacher prayed to God to change the white people. I've never heard a sermon in which they asked the Lord to stop prejudice. I've never heard a preacher preach that way to God, talking to God. There's all these people and they're talking to God in church. I've never heard them say that. I was a big boy, in high school and so forth, during the depression, in high school and in college, and I never heard anybody pray to let the stock market go up or something. You see? I don't know where all this stuff comes from. I'm concerned with what art does as an existential function of the intrinsic quality of life at a given time you see? And you get somebody else come in and they just listen and they talk, but they're not doing anything that's different. They're going to a honky tonk. If you want to hear the blues, they don't go to church to talk about injustice. When they go to church they talk about their soul after death, and whether or not they're going to qualify to enter the pearly gates. And I don't know any musician, unless he was seduced by people during the Communism binge that you know they came out of the depression, and then they write some lyrics for them to sing, but that's not aphrodisiac. The blues is aphrodisiac. You can't have a parallel of the blues and the socio-political position of the Negroes in the United States. It just isn't there. People want to put it there but it isn't. That's not what blues is about.

MR: So was the preacher's message instead of asking God to change the stock market or change the white person, was it more directed at the people themselves that he was talking to and for them to do right by themselves?

AM: Exactly. That's what I got in church. Until the day of the activist minister, you know such as Martin Luther King and people like that, where they join in with the Civil Rights Movement, and they began to use the church and so forth, and they just completely went on against the thing and got away with it in the United States. The United States got away from the basic doctrine — the separation of church and state. It's supposed to be something basic to America, why these people came over here, to separate the church from the state. But nobody ever thinks of that you know, because they're so busy making special rules when they deal with the so-called black idiom in the United States. They just go off and they've got piles of stuff all over, and it's nothing. It's not worth their time. So I was making a correlation between what these guys are doing you know? How do you make a jazz musician happy? By introducing him to some good looking girls at a party, and some whiskey if he likes it, or some other thing if he likes that. That's what makes a jazz musician happy. So they play just as well, some of the best jazz we have is during the depression.

MR: People seem to really value their entertainment even more during the depression, is that a fair statement? That even if they didn't have money to spend that they would really try their hardest to still get their entertainment?

AM: Yeah. Well they hadn't had that much money anyway. When did they have a lot of money? You know what I mean? They didn't have any money during slavery, right? The reconstruction was a rough time. Some people got rich but not many. I mean there was a lot of sharecropping and so forth and all, there is even peonage, stuff like that approaching it. In Mississippi for example, where all along the Delta and so forth, which gave rise to a style of the blues. It's very popular among New England college people and so forth, but I don't think they were doing the same thing. I mean they weren't even singing about freedom in the penitentiary. They were singing about sex and love and how they're being double crossed because they're in there, and they're singing about the man being mean, but it's basically because he's keeping him away from his girl, it seems to me. Then somebody could come, you could cajole somebody into it, but even if they did things which was news, in response to the news, like a flood of the Mississippi or something like that, it still wasn't about injustice or discrimination and stuff like that.

MR: Everyday life.

AM: Yeah. And their aspirations took these metaphorical forms you know. Like when — like the royal road as a form of improvement, liberation, going places, seeing the world, going to better conditions. That's true in all the mythologies that I know about. You have

seeking your fortune, going to seek your fortune. In America it might mean dollars and cents but in mythology it doesn't mean dollars and cents. It means your future — your good fortune or whatever was going to befall you, your destiny. You see what I mean? Whereas in America, in some instances, some American writers, it's all materialistic. Like they can't understand why those people could be having so much fun and they don't have the money. They [inaudible] that the people with the fun are not having the money are not having that. They're worried about the money you see? So they will have these people jumping out of windows because the stock market crashed, or things like that. They responded to it but they responded with affirmative music, with the emphasis on having a good time. I mean that's the thing. At the height of the depression it was the swing era. That's where they came in you see? So to get it confused with commiseration and stuff like that, is just to miss what it's about, and it's part of the confusion that comes out of what we call racism in America. Look at somebody and decide what they're about. And you decide what you think you are and then you say they're not this so they are that you see? And these people are only concerned with being human.

MR: How about a juice?

[pause]

AM: I think the problem is that many people, from the context that I come from, just sort of do what is expected of them. They're expected to be all activists, involved with this, as if that's what they live for. And I haven't found that to be so. I find people are very serious about social issues and things like that. I don't find that's what they spend most of their time doing. They end up doing, if they have a family, they try to do what you do as a member of a family, the father or mother of a family, to do what you can do by your children. And if you don't, they might be going out just having a good time and neglecting their children, but they're not out there dealing with social problems and addressing themselves to that. They don't live in terms of that. They live in terms of being human beings and they do what they're going to do. And they decide they're going to get this out of life, or they're going to get that out of life, and they decide maybe it'll add up to a form of hedonism, or it might add up to something else where a person might say well life is rough but it's just a sojourn anyway and we get ourselves ready for the afterlife. How is that different from what most of the people in Europe were doing during the middle ages? If you were a soldier, you used to build cathedrals and all. And we look at what they were eating, and where they were sleeping and all, and contrast that with the pride they took in the cathedral that they lived near, you see? If we keep looking at how human beings act, I mean and away from some ideological approach to human motives, you come nearer to understanding what their art form really expresses.

MR: Earlier today you made a statement that art isn't about innovation, it's about security. Could you explain that a little for me?

AM: The main problem out of which the necessity for art arose, is a problem of chaos, the problem of sanity, the problem of direction, the problem of prefiguration. That is, some image, some model, some form that will add up to a meaning. Because the main thing we live in is our consciousness. If you're unconscious, no, so what we need is protection against what would in effect be insanity. You wouldn't know up from down, inside from outside, you know, ugly from attractive if you didn't have some developed sensitivity to that. So what our perpetual quest is for would be durable form. Something dependable. The first thing you have is insecurity. The greatest problem of all is the problem of insecurity. Then you have things to take your mind off that, to put it in focus, to do something, rather than just wallow in insecurity. You couldn't exist very long in that you see? So that what we want are durable forms, images, ideals, which give what we call meaning and purpose to our existence, you know? Now this is a different thing from the pursuit of novelty, because novelty is something new, it's something you have to adjust to, see? It doesn't make for security, it makes for insecurity. It's something new you've got to learn. I mean I went to college in the 1930's and so forth. Nothing is more confusing to me than to walk down through these aisles and start looking at these computers, and the internet and all of that. That's innovation, and I'm a writer, and I don't have a computer. I use a computer, I dictate into a computer, but all that stuff that's required for that, I don't have time to go through that technology in order to do it. So I write with a ball point pen and then dictate it from legal pads to somebody who operates on that so I can read it and look at it and all. So the basic problem is with form. That's what they mean. That's what I get when we're talking about in the beginning was the word, was the form, was the concept, was that which adds up to an image of man you see? Or the earth was void, and He stirred it up, moved apart the waters and He said "let there be light." The word He was saying this. Suppose he said let there be darkness? Then you couldn't distinguish one thing from another, so that would be formless, right? That's what underlies the whole business of what an artist should do. He's trying to create a durable form which will enhance his consciousness, his sense of his own being, his sense of his possibility, his sense of the meaning of his relationship with other people. Now it changes when the existing form is inadequate. You see you have that problem. Always some people will get used to something as being the basis of their security, and they become what people call conservative. When everybody is conservative some other people become over conservative. They cling to it because it saved them the last time, and so they're used to that and they don't want to give that up until they are sure that something else is coming along that's going to give them the degree of security at least

that they had, a feeling of security. This is what we need. Remember, we're talking about the insecurity of formlessness you see? So that art is a basic part of that whole method, if not the basis of it you see? The patterns exist and so forth, and happen because you don't achieve a certain desirable pattern. It's a goal that somebody else invented and put out there. And you say it would be nice to be a college teacher or it would be nice to be a soprano in the thing, or it would be nice to be an architect. That's already out there. You're going to say it would be nice to be whatever it is they're going to have tomorrow. Nobody says that. Does that answer your question?

MR: Can I jump from what you're saying to the form of the blues, which seems to be so durable — it's 8, it's 12-bar or 16-bar — it seems to be so adaptable to different situations, the way the early folk blues singers used it and the way Count Basie used it. That idea of form, does that fit into what you are saying?

AM: Yeah, of course. It's security. It gives meaning. It keeps things connected. Suppose you couldn't remember anything. Wouldn't that be terrible? You couldn't remember anything. Well you wouldn't know what to do if you didn't have anything to remember you see? So you're obviously not trying to get rid of everything in your past. Because the past as I say is prologue. The door that we are going out of in the future is already there. It was there yesterday. You're constantly going on that which is there. This media thing we're doing, that was invented some years ago. It's already there. It's a door — we're going to wipe out that, we're not going to have any more television, any more tapes, because we're going to have something else. And then so they just gave you the digitals and they don't give you what it adds up to. They say this is what we're doing now. You see the little digits. How would you like that? That would be an innovation, but would you like it? No you would rather that the guy said, well what do they call that, either? The super imaging that you can get on television now?

TH: Digital video?

MR: Digital video?

AM: Well but there's another term they use for the whole thing. There's another adjective they used to describe it. You know like what, you've got virtual reality or something?

TH: High definition?

MR: High definition?

AM: High definition. I mean if a guy comes up and he gets low definition, and he says that's the latest thing, this is the newest thing is low definition, I mean would you go for that you see? No it's high definition. I mean you want more of what you have. You want it better. You understand what I'm saying? That's what we mean by that business of creativity. It's not a matter of changing. You don't want to change the thing until it's useless. Some people can be very insecure about that. They've got to be told that this is

better than what they have. To me that's very understandable. But you do have to be adventurous. You do have to be able to face change and all, but you shouldn't be idiotic about it. That is, just because it's new it's better. We know better than that in the culture in which we live, because we are simply looking for a new market. So if we can put something that cheaper and worse out, but has an effective advertising campaign to sell it, they're not going to do it better.

MR: They don't need to.

AM: You see? There's a lot of things that save us with the American automobile, once they got to a certain point. In the beginning they wanted to be durable. This will be better than a horse because the horse is going to die. So they built the automobiles that lasted as long as they could make them last. And later on they realized they could saturate the market with it, so they went in for built-in obsolescence. But they had a problem there, which worked in the average man's favor. And that is they had highway safety, do you see? So you couldn't build a death trap simply because it wouldn't last and it would fall apart. We've got laws to protect us against that. That's a protection against advertising. Because advertising would sell anything, and people would change in it just when it started. So they went in for that. They had to make it safe, because there was laws against it. So they put the emphasis — the legal requirements for safety, and put the emphasis on the design so the car is still good and still working but the guy's going to go buy another one because of the design. See that's the way they got around built in obsolescence in an area where the public welfare became the determining factor. Because we were into that at the time that the Germans and the Europeans were in for durability you see? They started making better automobiles. I mean the Volkswagen put all these people at a disadvantage, see? So they had all these fancy designs and all of a sudden a bunch of people, for a number of years, they said this is just transportation. I'm just going to work and back, and I need to get there and back, so the Volkswagen is fine. The Japanese said heck we can beat them. Look at all that space they're talking, there's too many cars in all those American cities and they're still making them bigger and bigger. They said we can get rid of that. It's going to be durable, it's going to be more reasonable in price, and that's what happened. That's what happened to the television, with high definition and all of that. I mean you go right to an American [inaudible], the biggest ever, they got SONYs in there. It's SONY right in there with their monitors and so forth. The best quality is what they buy. So the Japanese beat them because they sold the whole propaganda thing there was they were selling it based on fluff. And the guys say, we're going to base ours on efficiency. And all of a sudden, they were worried about the fact that all these people, so you go to Detroit to an auto factory, and these guys out there are making cars, but they're all driving Japanese.

MR: Do you think that the arts are —

AM: But you see that's the whole thing about that type of thing too, about innovation. So what turned out to be truly innovative was quality in automobile engines. You see what I mean? Delivered a good image at a reasonable price. So the guy who's making the American automobile, in a lot of instances you see, couldn't afford to buy it. So he's buying a Japanese car to drive to work to make automobiles. Another guy could see that and said I should have one of those you see? Because the Japanese were selling quality. Workmanship. Like the Swiss. The Swiss have always sold expertise and workmanship. They can take half the amount of coal and oil you see — one boatload of oil and it would be billions of dollars of Swiss skill, because they could ship it back — how many watches could you get out of that? How many instruments could you get out of that you see? Whereas in Norway you've got to have these big slabs of steel to make these boats. And they've got all these itty bitty — one boatload of that would be worth two of the boats. It's that type of thing that's involved in innovation and so forth. You've got to look at the quality. In the arts it's the same thing. But if you get marketing too closely, you could sell anything. You see that's how a lot of times we got stuck with such terrible music as we have in the United States now. You don't have to be a musician or to know music or to do anything. If the guy can sell it, if he can hype it, then he will turn that into the fad so all these people go running back because it's the in thing. A year from now or two years from now, in a short time in any case, that's gone. The guy's got the money, he's in something else. But he never was a musician, and this guy doesn't need a musician anymore.

MR: Right. But the marketing made this person able to be out there representing art. Do you think that music technology has hindered or helped the state of music today?

AM: Well I think — no I think the thing about music is the advertising that puts — any chance out there depends on the guy who has a very effective advertising campaign. That's a different thing. Because a lot of people who are going to want quality in their music, and there are people who want to be musicians. And in the arts, the guy will be it whether he gets paid for it or not, do you see what I mean? It's not that well I can't do this because, that's where the artist tends to be different in that certain people and certain functions in human society and civilization where people live for those values. Where in a materialist place like the United States, they think where is the money in it? You see? Well those people are doing it — they don't need so much money. I mean the last thing I need is a billion dollars. I mean I think I would be worried if I came into two billion dollars. What do I need with two billion dollars and I'm 81 years old? I don't need two billion dollars to go anywhere in the world, to get the best service in the best hotels, go anywhere, anytime, in the best places. I don't need to own an airplane to do that. You see? But all those

people have got to be responsible to keep up my airport, my yacht, my this and that — I don't need that. For that will get in the way. I have trouble getting —

MR: It would be a distraction to your art?

AM: I'm having trouble keeping up with the monthly statements that come in from investments and things, just a simple ordinary investment of a guy who retired as a major and who is a, like I say, college teacher and stuff like that. Just keeping up with the stuff like that mutual funds or this or that or the other, it's too much trouble. You know what I mean? So suppose I had to keep up with ten million dollars. I don't want to be bothered with that. I want to go to — see right now I want to get rid of the pain in my leg and my back. And I have enough money to do that, they just don't know how to do it, you see what I mean? The other money that I would want would enable me to go places that I'd like to go back to, or places I'd like to go to, and things like that. I don't need ten million dollars for that. I could have the best food, the best facilities, wear the type of clothes that I like to wear and I've been wearing ever since I finished college and things like that. I can afford all of that. I don't need ten million dollars for that. One thing I didn't get — you know one of the big things that I would have enjoyed having would have been a swimming pool. You know, like a place with a swimming pool. Something like either Florida or Beverly Hills, a small mansion. I wouldn't need that much room because if I had the stuff that I have now, if I had a mansion I'd put the stuff in it that I have now. I have the best stuff. I have the good paintings and the best books, and the best records. You see what I'm saying? Good furniture and all of that. So if I moved to Park Avenue or to Fifth Avenue, to one of those apartment houses, I would take the same stuff I have. Because I can afford that. So when I go to that house, I mean, many times, they don't have the same kind of tastes, do you see what I mean? I have the best sound equipment — on that level, do you see? When you think about the reality of the thing, and somebody's going to get all tied up trying to be rich and to stay rich, then they're beyond the basic requirements for a fine life let's say, a fine life. It doesn't take that much power or money to have a fine life. Because people are gifted with many more things than just enjoying life as such. They want to be in charge of something. They want to be boss, and they want to be running something. But it's good that there are people like that because they keep the other stuff going you see? Whether they want to run a railroad or an airline, then I can have the airline you see? So you've got all these different kinds of people but that's the way I feel about it. That you concentrate on the intrinsic things, and that doesn't mean changing to something new all the time.

MR: We seem to be in a hurry to do that a lot of times.

AM: Humh?

MR: We seem to be in a hurry to change.

AM: But that's advertising that's doing it. The guys got all that stuff in a warehouse and he's trying to sell it. That's basically what that is. So he goes to make you dissatisfied. Now he's already selling you something with a lifetime guarantee. So now he wants to make you dissatisfied so he can sell you something else. That's his problem. But in the arts you don't do that you see? The older the thing is, the better. Here's the newest thing in painting — you're going to give up a Rembrandt for that?

MR: Don't think so. Well we have a couple of minutes before I know you have to move on. And I wanted to read one thing in your book from Basie, and just have you comment on it. This is something he said: "it's the way you play it that makes it. What I say for Christ's sakes, you don't have to kill yourself to swing. Play like you play, play like you think, and then you got it, if you're going to get it, and whatever you get, that's you so that's your story." That was pretty much his philosophy on playing? That you don't have to work that hard at it? Although he made it seem easy I guess.

AM: Yeah. In other words he's saying what is in your range, and you can extend yourself to see what your range is you see, then you don't worry about what's beyond that. Do the best you can within that. If you can do that then you've got it if you're going to get it. If you're not, you're not. You see? So that he wasn't likened to everything that came along at all. And sure enough, his stuff is, like I said right along, his is the durable stuff. And it turns out what he would use, let's say there was bop. Basie was there before bop started. Basie was there when bop went out. Because how long did bop last? You know what I mean?

MR: Right.

AM: So by 1942 or 3, by 1955 they were talking about "cool." You know what I mean? That's a very short life. Although some people, now, got stuck in that, and they act like bop was day before yesterday. Like the guys — we hear that Dizzy Gillespie broke up at Lincoln Center last month, well early this month, this is still September, yeah? Yeah, earlier this month. It opened the season, and now people are acting as if that was yesterday. And John Lewis and I were talking about them playing the big — the band stuff, the full band stuff. And I would say I was at Carnegie Hall that night and when he played so-and-so he'd say "yeah man, do you realize that that was 50 years ago?" That was 1947.

MR: That's true. I'll be darned.

AM: I was in graduate school. And these guys act like that's the latest thing. And it's much older than King Oliver was when they were playing bop. King Oliver was still playing in the 1930s, right?

MR: Yeah. That's only 20 years before.

AM: You see what I'm saying?

MR: It's amazing how fast jazz has moved, yeah.

AM: Well the time has gotten there. There's a lot of fluctuations and interests and so forth, but the durable things are still there because they're still — like Basie you see? He could play stuff that he played, see that's the test of art. Can you play stuff that you played when you first came out of Kansas City. He could. I'm sure the last thing he played was "Jumpin' at the Woodside."

MR: The classics last, don't they.

AM: Yeah. Because the quality, you understand, the quality is durable. And that's where the security comes in, you see. If you've got something you're betting your life on today, then tomorrow it's out of style, then that's like trying to embrace entropy instead of making a bulwark against entropy. That's the big problem.

MR: Well I wish we could talk all day. But I know you have another engagement to go to. And so it's really been fascinating, and an honor to have you here on campus. So on behalf of Hamilton College, I'd like to thank you and wish you the best in the future.

AM: Well thank you. You know I feel like a grandson of Hamilton College because my favorite English teacher was from Hamilton. When I was a freshman, the guy that did a lot to inspire me to be a writer, or to embrace the field of literature and to become a writer, was from Hamilton. And I knew about Ezra Pound and people like that at Hamilton. And during that time Alexander Wolcott was a literary voice on radio and all, and he was Hamilton. And so I have always had a consciousness of Hamilton as a place of literary quality and I was especially pleased to get an honorary degree from Hamilton, because of Mr. Sprague, you see? So in a sense personally it is more significant to me than Princeton or something like that. Anyway, they bought into another thing you see? Whereas I bought into all the things I thought they were about. But it turned into something else. Because what I was thinking about was Thomas Mann had a house at Princeton and there was all kinds of guys at Princeton. So I associated with that and Francis Ferguson was writing that fine book on the theater, they had a lot of people. Edmund Wilson was a Princeton guy, and Dean Gauss, Dean Christian Gauss was a great mentor of literary people, but again they were buying in to something else. You know in the Science Department and all that they're still on the level of Einstein and so forth. But they don't have any way to look up — they do like the books where they're looking for a special type thing. What my stuff would do in effect would be to save Princeton, and all that effort, the effort that I thought they represented would be what mine is. Just get the humanities back up front. That's what I'm about you see? But they want to be politically correct and all of that which is nothing. That's just crap, you know what I mean? But if you get away from the fundamentals you see each time I start talking about it I want to get to something that's really basic and very fundamental. If your assumptions about

those are wrong then you're not going to get anywhere. Because the assumptions are wrong.

MR: Well we certainly appreciate your kind words about the college. It couldn't come from a more respected writer, and we're very glad to have you here. All right, thank you very much.

AM: All right.